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GADGETS



Amazon acquires Bee,
the AI wearable that
records everything you
say



Amazon has acquired the AI wearables startup Bee, according to a [LinkedIn post](#) by Bee co-founder Maria de Lourdes Zollo. Amazon confirmed the acquisition to TechCrunch but noted that the deal has not yet closed.

Bee, which raised [\\$7 million last year](#), makes both a stand-alone Fitbit-like bracelet (which retails for \$49.99, plus a [\\$19-per-month subscription](#)) and an Apple Watch app. The product [monitors](#) everything it hears — unless the user manually mutes it — with the goal of listening to conversations to create reminders and to-do lists for the user.

Zollo [told TechCrunch](#) last year that the company hopes to create a “cloud phone,” or a mirror of your phone that gives the personal Bee device access to the user’s accounts and notifications, making it possible to get reminders about events or send messages.

“We believe everyone should have access to a personal, ambient intelligence that feels less like a tool and more like a trusted companion. One that helps you reflect, remember, and move through the world more freely,” Bee [claims](#) on its website.

Other companies like [Rabbit](#) and [Humane AI](#) have tried to make AI-enabled wearables like this but have not found much success thus far. But at a \$50 price point, Bee’s devices are more cost-accessible to a curious consumer who doesn’t

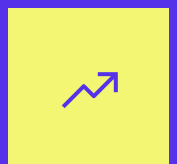
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want to make a big financial commitment. (The ill-fated Humane AI Pin was \$499.)

An Amazon spokesperson told TechCrunch that Bee employees received offers to join Amazon.

This acquisition signals Amazon's interest in developing wearable AI devices, a different avenue from its voice-controlled home assistant products like its line of Echo speakers. ChatGPT maker OpenAI is working on its own [AI hardware](#), while Meta is integrating its AI into its [smart glasses](#). Apple is [rumored](#) to be working on AI-powered smart glasses as well.

These products come with a number of security and privacy risks, given that they record everything around them; different companies' policies will vary in terms of how voice recordings are processed, stored, and used for AI training.

In its [current privacy policies](#), Bee says that users can delete their data at any time and that audio recordings are not saved, stored, or used for AI training. The app does store data that the AI learns about the user, however, which is how it can function as an assistant.

Bee previously indicated that it planned to only record the voices of people who have verbally consented. Bee also says it's working on a feature to allow users to define boundaries — both based on topic and location — that will automatically pause the device's learning. The company noted that it plans to build on-device AI processing, which generally poses less of a privacy risk than processing data in the cloud.

It's not clear if these policies will change as Bee is integrated into Amazon, however — and Amazon has a mixed record on the handling of user data from its customers' devices.

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In the past, Amazon [shared footage](#) with law enforcement from people’s personal Ring security cameras, with neither the owner’s consent, nor a warrant. Ring also settled [claims in 2023](#) brought by the Federal Trade Commission that employees and contractors had [broad and unrestricted access to customers’ videos](#).

Topics: [AI](#) [Amazon](#) [bee](#) [Gadgets](#) [Hardware](#)



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Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She...

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AI



Amazon expands
Bedrock with
conversational agents
and new third-party
models

Amazon continues to march unencumbered toward a generative AI future.

At AWS Summit New York, one of its annual conferences, Amazon announced the launch in preview of Agents for Bedrock — Bedrock being Amazon's platform that provides a way to build generative AI-powered apps via pretrained models from startups as well as Amazon itself.

Agents allows customers to create conversational agents to deliver personalized, up-to-date answers based on their proprietary data and execute actions.

IMAGE CREDITS: DAVID RYDER / GETTY IMAGES

In a briefing, Swami Sivasubramanian, the VP of machine learning at AWS, told TechCrunch that a company could use Agents to create a customer service chatbot that can process orders — tapping their internal information, including customer profiles and their return policy — to customize each order.

It's akin to the [plugins system](#) recently launched by OpenAI for its generative text AI, [GPT-4](#) and [ChatGPT](#), which similarly extends the models' functionality by letting them tap into third-party APIs and databases. Indeed, there's been a trend toward "personalized" generative models lately, with startups like [LlamaIndex](#) and [Contextual AI](#) building tools to augment models with enterprise data.

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“Bedrock Agents accelerate the delivery of generative AI applications that can manage and perform tasks by making API calls to your company systems,” Antje Barth, a principal developer advocate at AWS, explains in a blog post shared with TechCrunch via email. “Agents extend AI models to understand user requests, break down complex tasks into multiple steps, carry on a conversation to collect additional information, and take actions to fulfill the request.”

To figure out which actions to take, what information to use and in which sequence to perform actions, Bedrock Agents have to be shown how to “reason” through prompts that include definitions and instructions. These prompts are generated automatically in the back end through a series of configuration steps, one of which involves telling the Agent what task it’s supposed to perform and role it’s supposed to assume (e.g. “You’re an agent designed to help with processing insurance claims and managing pending paperwork”).

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The AI models powering Agents were developed internally by Amazon, a part of the company's Titan family of AI models. But Amazon's adding to the Bedrock library several models from third parties to coincide with the launch of Agents.

Anthropic's [Claude 2](#) text-generating AI and Stable Diffusion XL 1.0, the latest generative image model from AI startup [Stability AI](#), are both available in Bedrock as of today. So are two foundation models from Nvidia-backed [Cohere](#), specifically "Command text generation" and "Cohere Embed." (Command is trained to follow user commands and be useful in business applications like summarization, copywriting, dialogue, extraction and question-answering, while Embed can be applied in search or classification tasks across 100 or so languages.)

The growing range of models, including the models underpinning Agents, would seem to signal Amazon's seriousness about Bedrock — and, by extension, the generative AI field.

But Bedrock had a rocky start. Bloomberg [reported](#) in May that, six weeks after Amazon demoed the tech with an unusually vague presser and just one testimonial, most cloud customers still didn't have access.

Given AWS' massive reach and computational might, though, Bedrock could have a fighting chance. Time will tell.

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Kyle Wiggers

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Kyle Wiggers was TechCrunch's AI Editor until June 2025. His writing has appeared in VentureBeat and Digital...

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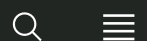
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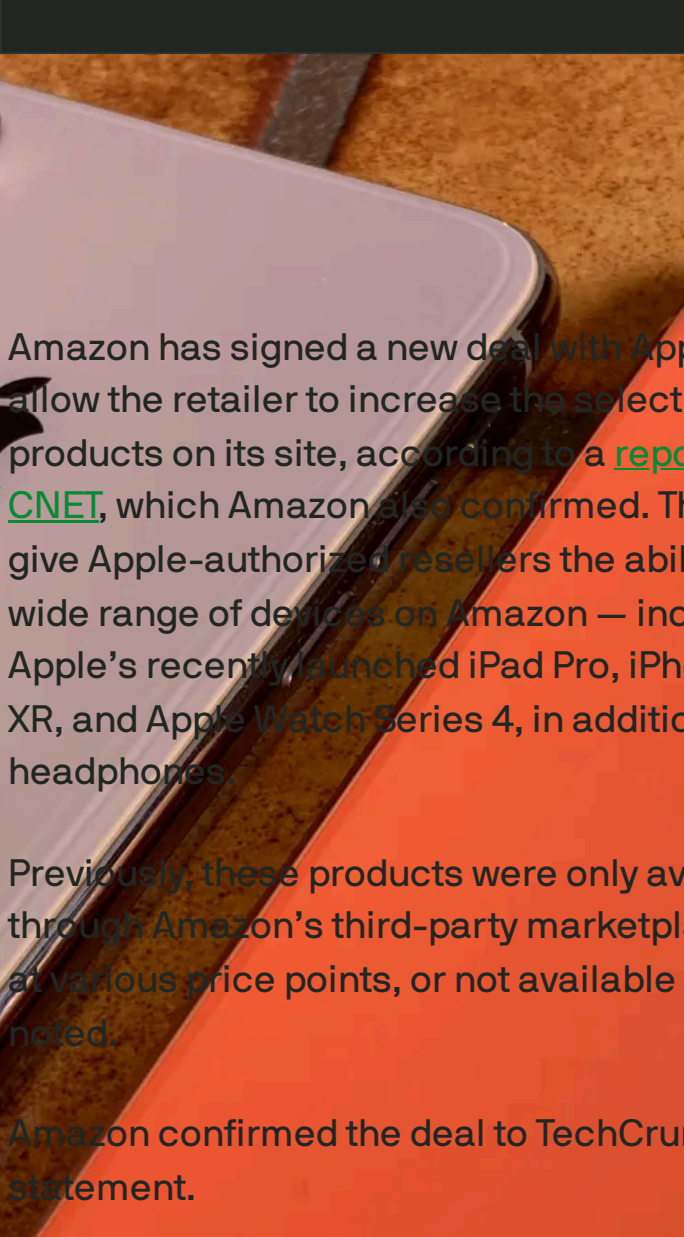


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Amazon has signed a new deal with Apple that will allow the retailer to increase the selection of Apple products on its site, according to a [report from CNET](#), which Amazon also confirmed. The deal will give Apple-authorized resellers the ability to sell a wide range of devices on Amazon — including Apple’s recently launched iPad Pro, iPhone XS and XR, and Apple Watch Series 4, in addition to Beats headphones.

Previously, these products were only available through Amazon’s third-party marketplace sellers at various price points, or not available at all, CNET noted.

Amazon confirmed the deal to TechCrunch in a statement.

“Amazon is constantly working to enhance the customer experience, and one of the ways we do this is by increasing selection of the products we know customers want,” an Amazon spokesperson said. “We look forward to expanding our assortment of Apple and Beats products globally.”

Apple, so far, has not responded to a request for comment.

CNET said the deal will impact the U.S., U.K., France, Germany, Italy, Spain, Japan and India.

The deal will also see Amazon removing the listings of Apple products from independent sellers, the report said.

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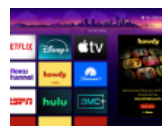
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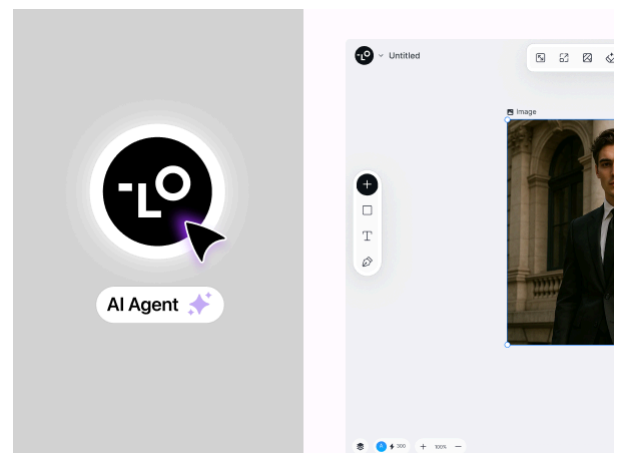
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The expansion is not surprising. Apple already allows Amazon to sell some of its devices, including MacBook laptops and Beats headphones.

The companies had been fierce rivals for years, but have been working together more amicably in recent months.

Before, the two had a number of issues between them. Notably, Amazon had stopped allowing the sale of Apple TV on its site, in order to promote its competing product, Fire TV. But Apple CEO Tim

Cook announced at WWDC 2017 that Apple and Amazon had come to an [agreement](#), which would also allow [Amazon's Prime Video app](#) to arrive on Apple TV.

The Apple TV also later [returned](#) to Amazon. This year, Amazon [launched a version of its FreeTime Unlimited](#) service for Apple's iOS devices, as well.

However, there is one notable exception to the new agreement: Amazon won't sell Apple's HomePod.

The HomePod competes with Amazon's Echo smart speakers, which is a growing opportunity in terms of Amazon's entry into voice computing and virtual assistants. The retailer also doesn't sell Google Home speakers at this time.

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Consumer News Editor |

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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Amazon's Apple Watch App Will Let You Shop From Your Wrist

Sarah Perez — 10:48 AM PDT · March 11, 2015

Though online retailer Amazon wasn't among one of the [many applications](#) Apple introduced this week as coming soon to its new wearable device, the [Apple Watch](#), the company does have an Apple Watch version of its mobile shopping app in the works, we understand. The shopping app will allow consumers to search for products and even buy them from their wrist using Amazon's 1-Click ordering system.

Of course, it's not surprising that Amazon will address the forthcoming mobile platform – after all, the company tends to release a version of its shopping app on almost any viable mobile or connected platform, not just its own Kindle hardware. And it already has an Android Wear (i.e., smartwatch) version of its shopping app in the wild, so it makes sense that it would build the Apple Watch counterpart, too.

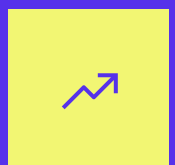
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In fact, our understanding is that the Apple Watch version of the Amazon shopping app will operate just like the current [Amazon app for Android Wear](#). That means it will support the ability to search for items using your voice, save products to your Amazon Wishlist, and even the ability to check out quickly using Amazon's 1-Click ordering. (Oh, this could be dangerous, I think.)

The retailer, however, is not officially confirming the details around its new Apple Watch app at this time, but instead is only hinting that such a thing is in the works. A company spokesperson told us the only statement they're offering for now is as follows:

"Amazon is constantly innovating on behalf of our customers. We are committed to being anywhere customers want to shop. That includes watches. We have an Amazon shopping app for Android Wear and will look to expand to other devices."

"Other devices" essentially confirms Amazon's plans to release an Apple Watch app, if you read between the lines, of course.

(Note: Above image is a mock-up.)

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